

cover story AGRICULTURE

its usage of words and describes even the biggest of crises in the mildest terms. But flashing in front of the prime minister was a chart that stated: "Foodgrain situation is quite alarming." It showed that the annual per capita foodgrain production had declined from a high 207 kg in 1995 to 186 kg last year—a level crossed way back in 1975. The average annual rate of growth of agriculture in the last five years was 1.87 per cent—possibly the lowest since Independence. Compare that with the 5-per cent growth in the mid-1980s, described as the golden period, and you would understand why this is now turning out to be the worst of times for agriculture.

In the last decade, there have been signs of stagnation everywhere. Overall land under foodgrains has remained at 120 million hectares and is showing signs of dropping further. Public investment in agriculture as a percentage of GDP has dropped from 3 per cent to around 1.7 per cent. Addition to irrigation was very low compared to previous decades. Groundwater tables have dropped rapidly and shortage of water for farming has reached crisis levels. Worse, there has been no technological breakthrough that can boost the yields of major foodgrains to produce a second Green Revolution.

Farmers across the country have taken a beating. Their incomes rose by a measly 0.28 per cent as compared to 4 per cent in other sectors. Not surprisingly, a recent national sample survey showed that 40 per cent of the farmers want to opt out of their current profession. And that every year, over



"The farming sector is fast heading for a total collapse if no rapid remedial measures are taken."

M.S. SWAMINATHAN, CHAIRMAN, NCF

20,000 farmers commit suicide out of despair over failing crops and impossibly high debt. "The situation is deteriorating rapidly and the entire farming sector is heading for a total collapse if no rapid remedial measures are taken," warns eminent agriculture scientist M.S. Swaminathan, who is currently chairman, National Commission on Farmers.

For Manmohan, who has just completed three years in the saddle, things could not have been worse. The ruling Congress party had already suffered a string of electoral setbacks in the Assembly elections. And a major downturn in a sector that employs over two-thirds of India's people was not what any doctor would have ordered. Not to mention the adverse impact of a rise in food prices any shortage will cause. So the prime minister moved with unusual alacrity to stem the rot. On May 29, the National Development Council, for the first time, convened a special session on food and agriculture that was attended by most chief ministers.

In his inaugural speech Manmohan said bluntly: "The rates of growth of agriculture in the last decade have been poor and are a major cause of rural distress. Farming is increasingly becoming an unviable activity." He announced, among other things, a mega Rs 25,000-crore assistance plan to states to give a push to agricultural productivity. There was a resolution to boost the growth rate of the sector to 4 per cent. But experts are not impressed. They saw the new measures as too little and too late. Here's why:



40% of the farmers want to opt out